

fridayReview

THE HINDU

More than a mridangist
K. Arun Prakash's passion for composing comes through in 'Solladi Sivashakti' **p2**

Preserving for posterity
Two conservation architects on using technology in restoration projects **p3**



THE WOMAN, THE VOICE, THE MENTOR

Musicians recall how S. Janaki touched lives through her music and warmth **p4**

Bindu Gopal Rao

It's 4 a.m., the sky, a deep indigo, is illuminated by fading stars and the air is crisp with the promise of dawn. The waris gear up to begin their annual 250 km yatra to the abode of Vithoba in Pandharpur. The men dressed in white dhoti or pyjama, kurta and the familiar Gandhi topi and women in vibrant *nauvari* (nine-yard sari worn in Maharashtra style) gather with saffron *patakas* (triangular flag) fluttering in the early morning breeze. Some carry instruments such as the *chipli* (wooden clappers), *mridanga* (drum), *tuturi* (curved brass horn) and *ektari* (stringed instrument). All through the journey they sing abhangs in unison till the yatra culminates on Ashadi Ekadashi.

The word 'abhang', meaning 'unbroken', are verses in praise of Vittala. Written in Marathi by saint-poets such as Dnyaneshwar, Namdev, Eknath and Tukaram, they were intended to make spiritual teachings accessible to the common man who could not understand Sanskrit. Over the years, abhangs have transcended from pilgrimage routes and temple courtyards to the concert stage. Renowned classical musicians such as Kishori Amonkar and Pt. Bhimsen Joshi have played a significant role in popularising them among wider audiences.

Says Hindustani vocalist and playback singer Mahesh Kale, "Today, it is heartening to see so many young faces at the abhang concerts I perform across the country at this time of the year. It shows how the expression of faith in these emotive verses is connecting with people. Language is no



On a new route (Clockwise from left) Abhang Repost band; Warkaris on the banks of Chandrabhaga; and Mahesh Kale at his abhangwari concert. PHOTOS: EMMANUAL YOGINI & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Abhang for a new age

Through multimedia presentations, fusion bands and digital platforms, musicians are reinventing this centuries-old music tradition

Vittala Vittala

- Pancham Nishad's 'Bolava Vitthal' concert, today at Chowdiah Memorial Hall, Bengaluru, 6.30 p.m.
- Mahesh Kale's multi-city Abhangwari concert series will have its next stopovers on July 18, 7 p.m. at Chamara Vajra, Palace Grounds, Bengaluru, and at Narada Gana Sabha, Chennai, on July 19, 5 p.m.

barrier. The audience response has been overwhelming and reassuring. It inspires me to constantly enhance the presentation of my Abhangwari concert series. For instance, I use multi-media projections and narration to make it more interactive. We also recreate a Vittala procession at the end of each concert to give audiences a real-time feel of the warkari sampradaya."

With musicians becoming more experimental with formats, abhang too is getting a contemporary twist. Mumbai-based Abhang Repost, a six-member folk fusion band, blends the devotional poetry with new-age sounds. The members, who have grown up listening to abhang, did some research to understand the deeper meaning of these songs before performing them. "They make you think," says bass guitarist Swapnil Tarphe. "The response has been phenomenal. After one of

our jamming sessions posted on Facebook garnered massive views, we were flooded with calls." From international tours to performing at major music festivals in the country, the band, which is all set to release its third album, admits music has no boundaries.

Chennai-based Carnatic vocalist Aruna Sairam is among the first to introduce abhang in kutcheris. "Having grown up in Mumbai, I was introduced to it at a young age. I have seen warkaris rendering them during their annual yatra. My mother also used to organise abhang sessions at home. The music and devotion left a deep impact on me. Much later, when I began performing kutcheris, I felt why not include abhnag in the tukkada section. The audiences' amazing response pushed me to even do exclusive abhang concerts."

Realising the enduring appeal of abhang, Shashi Vyas, founder of Pancham Nishad, launched the annual multi-city concert series Bolava Vitthala 15 years ago. Interestingly, it was he who suggested the title to Kishori Amonkar for her abhang concerts. "Today, more than 100 abhang concerts are held in Mumbai and other cities on Ashadi Ekadashi. Over the years, a dedicated following has led to abhang becoming a staple of classical music concerts. Composed centuries ago, these devotional verses continue to resonate across generations," he says.

CULTUREBRIEFS



Notes from Kerala

Sruti Foundation launches the book *Musicians of Kerala* by C. Ramakrishnan, which documents the lives and contributions of musicians from the state. Legendary musician T.V. Gopalakrishnan will release the book, and S. Janaki, former editor-in-chief of *Sruti* magazine, will receive the first copy. This will be followed by a thematic Carnatic concert, *Keralaleeyam*, in memory of N. Pattabhi Raman (founder of *Sruti*). It will feature songs by Kerala composers, and will be performed by K.S. Vishnudev (6.30 p.m.) with H.N. Bhaskar (violin), N.C. Bharadwaj (mridangam) and Chandrasekhara Sharma (ghatam). The event will take place today (6 p.m.) at The Music Academy mini hall.

Aaha! winds up

Aaha!, the digital dance festival conceived by Aravinth Kumarasamy, which was launched on June 1 on AVAI.video in collaboration with *The Hindu*, sought to create a curated space where dance lovers could watch works of merit. Though the festival has concluded, the performances are available for viewing for the next six months.

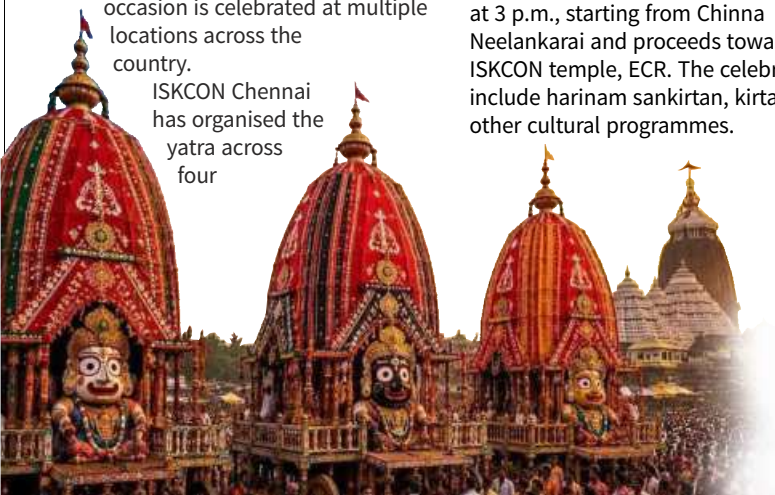
Many productions were conceived specifically for the digital medium, with artists treating the camera as a collaborator rather than a recording device. Close-up cinematography revealed the subtleties of abhinaya, while dynamic framing and editing opened perspectives unavailable in theatre. "Several works embraced site-specific locations and cinematic storytelling," says Aravinth, artistic director of the Singapore-based Apsaras Dance Company.

Aaha! became a meeting point for dancers, musicians, filmmakers and designers, fostering collaborations unique to the digital medium. "The initiative aimed to build a global home for Indian classical arts, documenting not only performances but also the creative processes behind them, ensuring these traditions evolve with integrity and relevance," says Mohanapriyan Thavarajah, curator of the festival.



Rath yatra

The annual Sri Puri Jagannath Rath Yatra, which marks the journey of Jagannath, Balabhadra and Subhadra from the Jagannath temple to Gundicha temple in wooden chariots, began yesterday in Odisha. The occasion is celebrated at multiple locations across the country. ISKCON Chennai has organised the yatra across four



locations which will end on July 19. The procession began yesterday from Anna Nagar and reached T. Nagar. Today's event will be a combined rath yatra, which will begin from Kannammal Street at Mugaliwakkam (3.30 p.m. to 6.30 p.m.), and end at Mugaleeshwar temple. The final procession will take place on July 19 at 3 p.m., starting from Chinna Neelankarai and proceeds towards ISKCON temple, ECR. The celebrations include harinam sankirtan, kirtan and other cultural programmes.

A different landscape

Aditya Madhavan's concert was themed on Muthuswamy Dikshitar's Pancha Bhuta Linga kritis



N.C. Srinivasaraghavan

Among the many thematic groupings in Muthuswami Dikshitar's repertoire, the Pancha Bhuta Linga kritis occupy a distinctive place. Dedicated to the five Shiva temples, representing the primordial elements – earth, water, fire, air and ether – these compositions weave together temple legends, philosophy and musical expression. As T.K. Govinda Rao observes in the book *Compositions of Mudduswami Dikshitar*, each kriti draws upon the sthala puranam of its respective kshetra, portraying the elemental manifestation of Shiva through rich poetic imagery and philosophical symbolism.

While these compositions are collectively known as the Pancha Bhuta kritis, historian V. Sriram observes that there is no conclusive evidence that Dikshitar himself conceived them as a formal compositional set. Nevertheless, they exhibit several common characteristics, including the conventional pallavi-anupallavi-charanam structure and the incorporation of raga mudras, features that are typical of many Dikshitar's compositions.

Thus, 'Jambupate mam pahi' in Yamuna Kalyani celebrates the Jambukeswara shrine at Thiruvanaikaval, where the linga is perpetually surrounded by an underground spring, symbolising the water (appu/jala) element. 'Cintaya ma kanda mulakandam' in Bhairavi recalls the legend of the ancient Ekamra mango tree at the Kanchipuram Ekambreswarar temple and Parvati's worship of the sand linga, representing the earth element. 'Arunachalanatham smarami' in Saranga evokes the celebrated legend of Shiva manifesting as the infinite column of fire at Tiruvannamalai. 'Sri kalahastisha' in Husseni extols the Vayu Linga at Srikalahasti and the sanctity of the shrine associated with the element of air, while 'Ananda natana prakasam' in Kedaram celebrates Nataraja's cosmic dance at Chidambaram, alluding to the Chidambara Rahasya and the ether (akasha) principle.

Taking up this theme for his concert, at Raga Sudha Hall as part of Guruguhaamrta's

mid-year music festival, Aditya Madhavan had a formidable task ahead of him in deciding how to structure the concert within a relatively short duration of about an hour and a half. While there is no prescribed order in which these compositions must be presented, each offers ample scope for manodharma in different forms. Bhairavi naturally lends itself as the prime candidate for the main composition ('Chintaya'), and Aditya chose to go ahead with this familiar choice, launching brightly into the upper octave in an alapana that was well thought out. Beginning the niraval at 'Mangalakara' directly in mel kalam, he went on to weave a fine kalpanaswara section, culminating in an engaging dialogue with violinist VSP Gayatri Sivani during the final swara exchange, centred around the panchamam. Mridangist Adharsh Devarajan's support was intuitive throughout the performance.

While Aditya concluded the concert with the slow and sedate Yamuna Kalyani piece, he began with the brisk Saranga kriti, embellishing it with second-speed kalpanaswaras. Moving on to the Husseni kriti, his alapana incorporated several characteristic phrases of the raga. A particularly striking passage, anchored around the upper shrishabham, stood out for his ability to sustain the note with poise and control. Rendering the kriti in Khanda Chapu, he maintained a steady gait that complemented the raga's emotive character.

'Ananda natana prakasam' was preceded by a tanam that showcased a pleasing variety of phrases. Gayatri Sivani offered an imaginative response. Aditya's enunciation of the tanam was precise, employing the appropriate syllabic patterns that made for an engaging listening. The same clarity extended to his kriti rendition, where the sahitya was articulated with commendable diction. His voice retained its sheen in the upper octave while remaining equally assured in the mandhara sthayi. The carefully conceived thematic presentation reaffirmed that Dikshitar's Pancha Bhuta Linga kritis continue to offer immense scope for both intellectual engagement and musical imagination.

Deepa Venkatraman

True to the opening lines of Mahakavi Subramania Bharati's song 'Nalladhore veenai seidhe, adhai nalam keda, puzhudhiyil yerivadhundo, Solladi Sivashakti' (You crafted a perfect veena. But would you let it go to waste, casting it into the dust to rot? Answer me, Sivashakti.)

These lines, in a way, reflect senior mridangist K. Arun Prakash's musical journey. He inherited his compositional talent from his father, L. Krishnan, a well-known composer, and has put it to good use in recent years. *Solladi Sivashakti*, his recent album is proof of it. It comprises Bharati's six compositions – 'Nalladhore Veenai', 'Veenaiyadi nee enakkur', 'Aaduvome', 'Kaakkai chiraginile', 'Theeradha vilayaatu pillai' and 'Senthamizh Nadennum', which have been sung by renowned vocalist Bombay Jayashri Ramnath. Though released in 2021, it has been streaming on Arun's YouTube channel since early this year. The highlight of the album is the use of live orchestration consisting of 30 musicians.

Says Arun, "If you want the emotions to remain intact, it is possible only with a live orchestra. Why substitute musicians?" According to Arun Prakash, live orchestra had largely disappeared in film-song recording by the 1990s. Seeking to revive that tradition, he has used the vibraphone on three tracks of *Solladi Sivashakti*. Veteran musicians who had once played for live recordings – vibraphone artiste Jeevanandam, violinist Rex Isaac, guitarist Sadhanandam, sitarist Kishore Lingappa, shehnai artiste Pt. Balesh, and percussionist S. Jayachandran (Jaychaa) – were happy to be part of the project," adds Arun. The recording, editing, mixing and mastering have been handled by Biju James.

Arun's conviction about the greater impact of live instrumentation took shape early, when he would analyse the music of film songs with



Rhythm and melody
K. Arun Prakash and Bombay Jayashri PHOTOS: RAJAPPANNE RAJU & K.V.S GIRI

If you want the emotions to remain intact, it is possible only with a live orchestra. Why substitute musicians?

Arun Prakash

Beyond the performer

The composer in mridangist Arun Prakash takes centre stage again with *Solladi Sivashakti*

his father, a disciple of G.N. Balasubramaniam. Bharati's verses have been an abiding influence on Arun since childhood. 'There is so much melody in his lyrics that the tune is merely an ornament.'

"Even as his career as a mridangist flourished from the mid-1980s, accompanying stalwarts such as D.K. Pattammal, K.V. Narayanaswamy, T.N. Krishnan, and Lalgudi G. Jayaraman, Arun continued to nurture his passion for composing. He created several pallavis, many of which were rendered by leading vocalists. 'The stage has been my greatest learning ground ever since I began accompanying on the mridangam at the age of 11,' he says.

Inspired by the music of



maestros Ilaiyaraaja and M.S. Viswanathan, Arun composed his first tune in Mohanakalyani at the age of 17. He later worked on projects such as 'The seppu mozhi padinetu' (based on Bharati's verses), 'Shrirama jayarama' (multi-lingual songs on Rama), 'Sundara amudha gaanam' (songs by Sundara Valli Ammal) and

'Nadaswara amudham' (Carnatic orchestra).

Little did he know that the tunes he composed between 2004 and 2008, largely as a creative exercise, would one day find their way into a variety of musical initiatives. Talking about his latest venture *Solladi Sivasakthi*, Arun recalls how it all began. "I had given Bombay Jayashri

The M.A. Narasimhachar Music Foundation in Bengaluru commemorates its 25th anniversary with a year-long series of Carnatic music and cultural events, honouring the legacy of musician M.A. Narasimhachar, who hailed from Mysuru.

He was born in 1924. It was from his home that he established Gana Kala Mandira, an intimate yet influential concert space that hosted many of 20th century's well-known Carnatic musicians including Ariyakudi Ramanuja Iyengar, Semmangudi Srinivasa Iyer and Umayalpuram Sivaraman. It was an important meeting point



Celebrating a legacy

for musicians and rasikas. Even in his later years, Narasimhachar spoke with enthusiasm about his gurus including Tiger Varadachariar, Sabesa Iyer, Ponniah Pillai, Sattur Krishna Iyengar and T.K. Rangachar for initiating him into the tradition. He also studied Western music through courses conducted by Trinity College London.

Gana Kala Mandira celebrated its diamond jubilee in 2002. Though it no longer exists, its legacy continues through the M.A. Narasimhachar Music Foundation, established by his son, Sri Kishan.

Over the past 25 years, it has evolved into a significant presence

in Bengaluru's cultural landscape. At its silver jubilee year, the foundation stands as a continuation of a musical tradition that began in Mysuru more than eight decades ago.

The celebrations begin with vocalist Sandeep Narayan's concert on July 18, followed by Ranjani and Gayatri's performance on July 19. The commemorative season will culminate in a 10-day music festival from November 20. The venue will be Gayana Samaja, Bengaluru.

All the events are non-ticketed, continuing Narasimhachar's commitment to making art accessible.

Dual template

Sreya and Rajalakshmi's recital was a blend of raga bhava and rhythmic exploration

Aishwarya Raghunathan

The vocal duet by Sarvepalli sisters, Sreya and Rajalakshmi, who performed at The Music Academy's Radel mid-year concerts, was built almost entirely around

compositions on Devi. They were supported by Pantula Vennela on the violin and S. Srivatsa on the mridangam.

The concert opened with 'Arunodayame anbin vadivame', a varnam by Lalgudi Jayaraman set in Bowli – a raga known for its serene and meditative quality,



making it a impressive curtain-raiser. The sisters' coordination held firm through the piece.

'Vandi suvadadiyali', a Purandaradasa composition in Nattai, came up next. A few sangatis at the anupallavi

showed minor mismatches between the two voices. However, the kalpanaswaras at 'Gananathana', were rendered with confidence that compensated for the minor lapses occurred in the anupallavi.

Rajalakshmi's alapana in Saranga Tarangini was the first major exposition, which was matched by an assured violin response from Pantula Vennela. 'Samana rahethe amba', a G.N. Balasubramaniam

In sync Sarvepalli Sisters – Sreya and Rajalakshmi. PHOTO:M. SRINATH

composition, followed, with kalpanaswaras cast in tisram. Throughout this segment, Srivatsa's mridangam prayogams were well-rounded.

'Vararagalaya' by Tyagaraja, in Chenchu Kamboji at melkala arrived as a spark. The kriti was popularised by GNB.

Sreya's Thodi alapana – the day's centrepiece – incorporated grahabedam passages in Mohanam and Hindolam; Vennela's violin response explored Mohana Kalyani instead, explicitly placing a phrase from the Mohana Kalyani thillana. 'Koluva maregadha' (Tyagaraja) carried a niraval

at 'Sri karuniki sritha'. The kalpanaswara that followed bore the stamp of their guru, Sudha Raganathan. Their deliberate off-beat phrases resisted settling into either tisram or chatusram, a hallmark of the bani, which demands considerable rhythmic control and precision. The tani that followed gave Srivatsa room to explore different patterns.

'Prasarathu devi', a melkala composition by Ganapathi Sachchidananda Swami in Atana, offered rhythmic vitality. The Tiruppugazh virutham 'En thayum ennarul', from Arunagirinathar's *Kandhan Anuboothi*, seamlessly transitioned into Lalgudi Jayaraman's Behag thillana. The concert closed with 'Devi viratrupa' another kriti by Ganapathi Sachchidananda Swami in raga Revagupti.

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CALENDAR

- Lecture demonstration on 'Devi Kshetra Darshanam with the compositions of Sri Shyama Shastri' (July 18, 10 a.m.) by R.K. Shriramkumar. Amritha Murali will lend vocal support with Madan Mohan accompanying on the violin and K. Arun Prakash on the mridangam.

A photograph of three large, light-colored, abstract panels with dark, irregular markings, displayed in a wooden frame. The panels are arranged side-by-side and are held in place by a wooden frame. The background is a dark wall with some framed pictures.

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